

The Open Window

Saki (H. H. Munro) · 1914

First published: Beasts and Super-Beasts, 1914

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Beasts_and_Super-Beasts/The_Open_Window (revision 10921512), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Open Window suggest about deception and storytelling?
- What does The Open Window suggest about nerves and credulity?
- What does The Open Window suggest about romance as invention?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Open Window	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*deception and storytelling* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Open Window

Author biography

Saki was the pen name of Hector Hugh Munro, born in Akyab, Burma (now Sittwe, Myanmar), on 18 December 1870. After his mother's death he was raised in Devon by strict aunts, a childhood that may lie behind his stories of clever children outwitting adults. He worked as a journalist and foreign correspondent and wrote witty, often cruel stories of Edwardian society. At 43 he enlisted as a private in the First World War and was killed by a sniper in France on 14 November 1916.

Historical and cultural context

Set in an English country house with Edwardian social customs, such as letters of introduction.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Beasts and Super-Beasts (1914); earlier in the Westminster Gazette (1911).

Then: Popular.

Now: A classic of the comic twist.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Nervous Framton Nuttel, on a rest cure, visits Mrs. Sappleton; her niece, Vera, tells him a tragic story about the open window.

Main themes

- deception.
- storytelling.
- appearance versus reality.

Why it matters

It shows how a storyteller manipulates an audience.

Spoilers · teacher only

The "ghosts" are the living men returning, and Framton flees; Vera invents another story about him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Open Window: Have you ever been pranked?
Prompt: Before we open The Open Window: Have you ever been pranked?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

irony; twist ending; unreliable narrator within a story.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Saki was the pen name of Hector Hugh Munro, born in Akyab, Burma (now Sittwe, Myanmar), on 18 December 1870. After his mother's death he was raised in Devon by strict aunts, a childhood that may lie behind his stories of clever children outwitting adults. He worked as a journalist and foreign correspondent and wrote witty, often cruel stories of Edwardian society. At 43 he enlisted as a private in the First World War and was killed by a sniper in France on 14 November 1916. The world of the book. Set in an English country house with Edwardian social customs, such as letters of introduction. Publication and reception. Published in Beasts and Super-Beasts (1914); earlier in the Westminster Gazette (1911). Then: Popular. Now: A classic of the comic twist.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29). The last line.

> *Romance at short notice was her speciality (The Open Window, paragraph 29)*

Think-aloud: "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29). The last line.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Nervous Framton Nuttel, on a rest cure, visits Mrs. Sappleton; her niece, Vera, tells him a tragic story about the open window. Themes to track: deception.: storytelling.: appearance versus reality.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Open Window: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Open Window still matter? It shows how a storyteller manipulates an audience.
Anchor question: Why might The Open Window still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how a storyteller manipulates an audience.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why is Framton easy to fool? Answer: He is nervous and a stranger.
Exit ticket: Why is Framton easy to fool?
Answer: He is nervous and a stranger.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Open Window.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Saki" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Saki); Saki, Beasts and Super-Beasts (1914) (https://www.gutenberg.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Verify the Westminster Gazette date.

Lesson 2: The Open Window

Focus: a story so convincing it becomes real

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Nervous Framton Nuttel visits the Sappletons for a rest cure. While waiting, fifteen-year-old Vera tells him her aunt keeps the French window open because her husband and brothers vanished in a bog three years ago and she expects them back. When the men appear at the window with a spaniel, Framton flees in terror. Vera calmly invents a new story to explain his flight. 'Romance at short notice was her speciality.'

Background: Published in 1914 in Beasts and Super-Beasts. Saki (H. H. Munro) satirized Edwardian country-house society.

Significance: A short masterpiece of the twist ending; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What makes a lie believable? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to deception because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: What makes a lie believable?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to deception because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: speciality — a particular skill or thing a person is known for; discounting — disregarding or not taking seriously; mackintosh — a raincoat; engulfed — swallowed up completely; carpets — floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile).
Words: speciality: a particular skill or thing a person is known for · discounting: disregarding or not taking seriously · mackintosh: a raincoat · engulfed: swallowed up completely · carpets: floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1914 in Beasts and Super-Beasts. Saki (H. H. Munro) satirized Edwardian country-house society. A short masterpiece of the twist ending; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1. Irony: Dramatic irony is withheld: the reader believes Vera as Framton does, so the twist catches both. Characterization: Vera, "a very self-possessed young lady of fifteen," invents with total composure; Framton is anxious, self-absorbed and easy prey. Structure: A story within a story: Vera's ghost tale inside the visit, and a second invented tale (about Framton and the dogs) at the end. Watch for the open window: the opening through which Vera's fiction and the real world meet.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29). The reveal. That is irony at work: Dramatic irony is withheld: the reader believes Vera as Framton does, so the twist catches both.

> *Romance at short notice was her speciality* (The Open Window, paragraph 29)

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29). The reveal. That is irony at work: Dramatic irony is withheld: the reader believes Vera as Framton does, so the twist catches both.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The precise detail ("just three years ago") and her calm make the lie convincing; specificity is the liar's tool. Ask: How does this line connect to deception? Expected: A young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. (Vera's story.)

> *Her great tragedy happened just three years ago* (The Open Window, paragraph 10)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The precise detail ("just three years ago") and her calm make the lie convincing; specificity is the liar's tool.
Ask: How does this line connect to deception?
Expected answer: A young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. (Vera's story.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a story so convincing it becomes real? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Window develops the idea of a story so convincing it becomes real. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. When the text says "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29), it shows this directly. She invents "Her great tragedy" so convincingly that Framton flees, and the narrator says "Romance at short notice was her speciality."
Task: Annotate the story for irony, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a story so convincing it becomes real? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Window develops the idea of a story so convincing it becomes real. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. When the text says "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29), it shows this directly. She invents "Her great tragedy" so convincingly that Framton flees, and the narrator says "Romance at short notice was her speciality."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What makes a lie believable? Ask: is Vera cruel?
Anchor question: What makes a lie believable?
Facilitation: Ask: is Vera cruel?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a story so convincing it becomes real? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. ("Romance at short notice was her speciality", The Open Window, paragraph 29). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a story so convincing it becomes real? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. ("Romance at short notice was her speciality", The Open Window, paragraph 29). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes a story so convincing it becomes real. Key takeaway: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Dramatic irony is withheld: the reader believes Vera as Framton does, so the twist catches both.
- **Characterization:** Vera, "a very self-possessed young lady of fifteen," invents with total composure; Framton is anxious, self-absorbed and easy prey.
- **Structure:** A story within a story: Vera's ghost tale inside the visit, and a second invented tale (about Framton and the dogs) at the end.

Themes and how they develop

- **deception:** a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling.

Symbols and motifs

- **the open window:** the opening through which Vera's fiction and the real world meet.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Romance at short notice was her speciality” (The Open Window, paragraph 29) The reveal.
- “nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing” (The Open Window, paragraph 2) Framton.
- “Her great tragedy happened just three years ago” (The Open Window, paragraph 10) Vera's story.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Vera's skill shows the power of a story.
Evidence: “Romance at short notice was her speciality” (The Open Window, paragraph 29)
Reasoning: She invents "Her great tragedy" so convincingly that Framton flees, and the narrator says "Romance at short notice was her speciality."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
speciality (noun)	a particular skill or thing a person is known for	*Romance at short notice was her speciality.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
discounting (verb)	disregarding or not taking seriously	*Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mackintosh (noun)	a raincoat	*“Here we are, my dear,” said the bearer of the white mackintosh, coming in through the window; “fairly muddy, but most of it’s dry.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

engulfed (verb)	swallowed up completely	*In crossing the moor to their favourite snipe-shooting ground they were all three engulfed in a treacherous piece of bog.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
carpets (noun)	floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)	*They've been out for snipe in the marshes to-day, so they'll make a fine mess over my poor carpets.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
indicating (verb)	showing; pointing to	*"You may wonder why we keep that window wide open on an October afternoon," said the niece, indicating a large French window that opened on to a lawn.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
coincidence (noun)	an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental	*It was certainly an unfortunate coincidence that he should have paid his visit on this tragic anniversary.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
staying (verb)	remaining	*"My sister was staying here, at the rectory, you know, some four years ago, and she gave me letters of introduction to some of the people here."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What makes a lie believable?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with deception and storytelling?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why is Framton visiting the country? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: For a nerve cure
2. Who tells Framton about the open window? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Vera, the niece
3. What does Vera claim happened three years ago? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Her uncle and his brothers died in a bog
4. What makes Framton flee? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: The men appear walking toward the window
5. What is Vera's 'speciality'? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Romance at short notice: inventing stories

6. Retell the three most important events of “The Open Window” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Nervous Framton Nuttel visits the Sappletons for a rest cure. While waiting, fifteen-year-old Vera tells him her aunt keeps the French window open because her husband and brothers vanished in a bog three years ago and she expects them back. When the men appear at the window with a spaniel, Framton flees in terror. Vera calmly invents a new story to explain his flight. 'Romance at short notice was…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Open Window”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Open Window” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Romance at short notice was her speciality.” What does “speciality” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: speciality: a particular skill or thing a person is known for.
10. Reread: “Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come.” What does “discounting” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: discounting: disregarding or not taking seriously.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Open Window” suggest about a story so convincing it becomes real? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A short masterpiece of the twist ending; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a story so convincing it becomes real? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: “Romance at short notice was her speciality” (The Open Window, paragraph 29): The reveal. On characterization: Vera, "a very self-possessed young lady of fifteen," invents with total composure; Framton is anxious, self-absorbed and easy prey. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come.”, why might Munro) have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Open Window”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Nervous Framton Nuttel visits the Sappletons for a rest cure. While waiting, fifteen-year-old Vera tells him her aunt keeps the French window open because her husband and brothers vanished in a bog three years ago and she expects them back. When the men appear at the window with a spaniel, Framton…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Open Window” set up that the rest of The Open Window will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence:

"nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing" (The Open Window, paragraph 2): Framton. On structure: A story within a story: Vera's ghost tale inside the visit, and a second invented tale (about Framton and the dogs) at the end. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Her great tragedy happened just three years ago" (The Open Window, paragraph 10): Vera's story. On characterization: Vera, "a very self-possessed young lady of fifteen," invents with total composure; Framton is anxious, self-absorbed and easy prey. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "What makes a lie believable?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with deception and storytelling? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29): The reveal. On structure: A story within a story: Vera's ghost tale inside the visit, and a second invented tale (about Framton and the dogs) at the end. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1914 in Beasts and Super-Beasts. Saki (H. H. Munro) satirized Edwardian country-house society. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing" (The Open Window, paragraph 2): Framton. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A short masterpiece of the twist ending; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Her great tragedy happened just three years ago" (The Open Window, paragraph 10): Vera's story. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29): The reveal. On characterization: Vera, "a very self-possessed young lady of fifteen," invents with total composure; Framton

is anxious, self-absorbed and easy prey. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of "The Open Window" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a story so convincing it becomes real? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing" (The Open Window, paragraph 2): Framton. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about "The Open Window": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Her great tragedy happened just three years ago" (The Open Window, paragraph 10): Vera's story. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to nerves and credulity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Munro) need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29): The reveal. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing" (The Open Window, paragraph 2): Framton. On irony: Dramatic irony is withheld: the reader believes Vera as Framton does, so the twist catches both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "The Open Window" treats a story so convincing it becomes real with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Open Window see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Her great tragedy happened just three years ago" (The Open Window, paragraph 10): Vera's story. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve deception and storytelling? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: "Romance at short notice was her speciality" (The Open Window, paragraph 29): The reveal. Theme link:

a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a story so convincing it becomes real? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: “nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing” (The Open Window, paragraph 2): Framton. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Saki (H. H. Munro) about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Vera's skill shows the power of a story. Useful evidence: “Her great tragedy happened just three years ago” (The Open Window, paragraph 10): Vera's story. Theme link: a young girl, with little social power, controls the adults through storytelling. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Why is Framton visiting the country?
   A. For a nerve cure
   B. To see his sister
   C. To hunt
   D. To buy land
2. Who tells Framton about the open window?
   A. His sister
   B. Vera, the niece
   C. Mrs. Sappleton
   D. A servant
3. What does Vera claim happened three years ago?
   A. Her uncle and his brothers died in a bog
   B. The house burned
   C. A dog drowned
   D. Her aunt went mad
4. What makes Framton flee?
   A. A ghost appears

B. The dog bites him

C. The men appear walking toward the window

D. Mrs. Sappleton screams

5. What is Vera's 'speciality'?

A. Gardening

B. Hunting

C. Music

D. Romance at short notice: inventing stories

6. In the line “Romance at short notice was her speciality.”, what does “speciality” most nearly mean?

A. a raincoat

B. disregarding or not taking seriously

C. swallowed up completely

D. a particular skill or thing a person is known for

7. In the line “Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come.”, what does “discounting” most nearly mean?

A. a raincoat

B. a particular skill or thing a person is known for

C. disregarding or not taking seriously

D. swallowed up completely

Answer key: 1. A (For a nerve cure); 2. B (Vera, the niece); 3. A (Her uncle and his brothers died in a bog); 4. C (The men appear walking toward the window); 5. D (Romance at short notice: inventing stories); 6. D (a particular skill or thing a person is known for); 7. C (disregarding or not taking seriously)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Open Window,” how does Munro) show a story so convincing it becomes real? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Open Window, how does Munro) develop the idea of a story so convincing it becomes real? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Open Window develops the idea of a story so convincing it becomes real. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Open Window (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a story so convincing it becomes real. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Open Window suggests about a story so convincing it becomes real. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Saki (H. H. Munro) uses irony in The Open Window to complicate the reader's understanding of a story so convincing it becomes real. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Open Window within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a story so convincing it becomes real responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Open Window alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a story so convincing it becomes real follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Open Window and its treatment of a story so convincing it becomes real. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Open Window as evidence for a larger claim about a story so convincing it becomes real in The Open Window. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Open Window as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a story so convincing it becomes real. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Open Window.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Here we are, my dear," said the bearer of the white mackintosh, coming in through the window; "fairly muddy, but most of it's dry.*

As used in the text, what does the word "mackintosh" most nearly mean?

A. remaining

B. a raincoat

C. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental

D. showing; pointing to

2. *Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come. Privately he doubted more than ever whether these formal visits on a succession of total strangers would do much towards helping the nerve cure which he was supposed to be undergoing.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Open Window"?

A. A story told to protect a livelihood

B. A story so convincing it becomes real

C. Waking into a changed nation

D. Friendship tested by duty

SAT key: 1. B (a raincoat); 2. B (A story so convincing it becomes real)

Whole-book test

The Open Window: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why is Framton visiting the country?
   A. For a nerve cure
   B. To see his sister
   C. To hunt
   D. To buy land
2. Who tells Framton about the open window?
   A. His sister
   B. Vera, the niece
   C. Mrs. Sappleton
   D. A servant
3. What does Vera claim happened three years ago?
   A. Her uncle and his brothers died in a bog
   B. The house burned
   C. A dog drowned
   D. Her aunt went mad
4. What makes Framton flee?
   A. A ghost appears
   B. The dog bites him
   C. The men appear walking toward the window
   D. Mrs. Sappleton screams
5. What is Vera's 'speciality'?
   A. Gardening
   B. Hunting
   C. Music
   D. Romance at short notice: inventing stories
6. In the line “Romance at short notice was her speciality.”, what does “speciality” most nearly mean?
   A. a raincoat
   B. disregarding or not taking seriously
   C. swallowed up completely
   D. a particular skill or thing a person is known for

7. In the line “Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aunt that was to come.”, what does “discounting” most nearly mean?
   A. a raincoat
   B. a particular skill or thing a person is known for
   C. disregarding or not taking seriously
   D. swallowed up completely
8. As used in the story (“Romance at short notice was her speciality.”), what does “speciality” mean?
   A. a particular skill or thing a person is known for
   B. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
   C. remaining
   D. swallowed up completely
9. As used in the story (“Framton Nuttel endeavoured to say the correct something which should duly flatter the niece of the moment without unduly discounting the aun”), what does “discounting” mean?
   A. showing; pointing to
   B. disregarding or not taking seriously
   C. a particular skill or thing a person is known for
   D. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
10. As used in the story (““Here we are, my dear,” said the bearer of the white mackintosh, coming in through the window; “fairly muddy, but most of it’s dry.”), what does “mackintosh” mean?
    A. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
    B. disregarding or not taking seriously
    C. a raincoat
    D. showing; pointing to
11. As used in the story (“In crossing the moor to their favourite snipe-shooting ground they were all three engulfed in a treacherous piece of bog.”), what does “engulfed” mean?
    A. remaining
    B. a raincoat
    C. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
    D. swallowed up completely
12. As used in the story (“They’ve been out for snipe in the marshes to-day, so they’ll make a fine mess over my poor carpets.”), what does “carpets” mean?
    A. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
    B. a particular skill or thing a person is known for
    C. swallowed up completely
    D. remaining

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how deception and storytelling develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how nerves and credulity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how romance as invention develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (deception and storytelling, nerves and credulity, romance as invention) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (For a nerve cure); 2. B (Vera, the niece); 3. A (Her uncle and his brothers died in a bog); 4. C (The men appear walking toward the window); 5. D (Romance at short notice: inventing stories); 6. D (a particular skill or thing a person is known for); 7. C (disregarding or not taking seriously); 8. A (a particular skill or thing a person is known for); 9. B (disregarding or not taking seriously); 10. C (a raincoat); 11. D (swallowed up completely); 12. A (floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile))

Essay assignments

Essay: Deception and storytelling

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Window teaches about deception and storytelling. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops deception and storytelling in The Open Window. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops deception and storytelling across The Open Window. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Window (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of deception and storytelling. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of deception and storytelling in The Open Window. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Saki (H. H. Munro)'s choices in The Open Window (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of deception and storytelling, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Window's treatment of deception and storytelling in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on deception and storytelling in The Open Window that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on deception and storytelling in The Open Window. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about deception and storytelling in The Open Window, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on deception and storytelling in The Open Window, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Nerves and credulity

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Window teaches about nerves and credulity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops nerves and credulity in The Open Window. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops nerves and credulity across The Open Window. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Window (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nerves and credulity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nerves and credulity in The Open Window. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Saki (H. H. Munro)'s choices in The Open Window (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nerves and credulity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Window's treatment of nerves and credulity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nerves and credulity in The Open Window that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nerves and credulity in The Open Window. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nerves and credulity in The Open Window, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nerves and credulity in The Open Window, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Romance as invention

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Window teaches about romance as invention. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops romance as invention in The Open Window. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Saki (H. H. Munro) develops romance as invention across The Open Window. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Window (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of romance as invention. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of romance as invention in The Open Window. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Saki (H. H. Munro)'s choices in The Open Window (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of romance as invention, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Window's treatment of romance as invention in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on romance as invention in The Open Window that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on romance as invention in The Open Window. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about romance as invention in The Open Window, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on romance as invention in The Open Window, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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